of the world, aside from South Africa. So the question has to be asked: why is South Africa in the BRICS? Simply put, the reality is that South Africa is seen as a gateway for corporations into Africa, be they energy or financial corporations. This is because of South Africa's vast footprint on the continent.

Remember Thabo Mbeki's peace missions? Well, they were not all about peace; they were about getting South African companies established in areas of unrest so that when peace happens they are there first to exploit the resources in these countries. This could potentially be a negative role if South Africa is only used as a gateway to facilitate resource extraction and exploitation of Africa by BRICS countries, as it is now used by the West. The question has to be asked by South Africans: why do we allow this? I do not have the answer.

Returning to poverty alleviation, the reality is that in the BRICS countries we have the highest gap between those who earn the most and the poor, and this gap is growing. Calling the bluff of poverty alleviation is critical. How to unpack this opaque agenda of the BRICS governments is a challenge, for while their talk is about poverty alleviation the reality is something else.

We recognise that what the BRICS are doing is nothing more than what the North has been doing to the South, but as we resist these practices from the North, we must be bold enough to resist these practices from our fellow countries in the South. Thus, critically, the challenge going forward for society is to understand the BRICS and, given how much is at stake, civil society must scrutinise the claims, the processes and the outcomes of the BRICS summit and its aftermath, and build a strong criticism of the BRICS that demands equality and not new forms of exploitation.

BRICS seen from Zimbabwe (by Farai Maguwu)

Zimbabwe's latest economic blueprint, known by its abbreviated form, Zim Asset, identifies BRICS as central to the country's economic revival. There has been an upsurge of Russian, Chinese and South African investments in Zimbabwe's extractive sector over the past decade, but mining has been characterised by environmental degradation, tax evasion, human rights abuses and exploitative labour practices. No one knows whether Zimbabwe stands to benefit from BRICS, nor does the government have clearly stated objectives or a well-defined strategy of getting the most out of BRICS. Even the much celebrated 'Look East Policy' remains more of a political slogan than a coherent strategy.

The biggest dilemma is how to turn around the extraction and externalisation of resources, and generate a patriotic path for capital accumulation arising from diamonds, platinum, gold, chrome and other minerals. In order to achieve